How Brandy Is Made

From wine — and pomace, and ripe fruit — to spirit: how France distils its great brandies. Tap any step to open the details, hover the **underlined terms** for a quick definition.

Cognac

1. Harvest *Vendange*

Cognac begins with tart, thin white wine — almost always from **ugni blanc**, picked while acidity is high and sugar low. The best come from the chalky crus around **grande champagne**.

Why it matters: a sharp, low-alcohol wine is a poor drink but the ideal raw spirit — clean and neutral enough to reward distillation.

2. Fermentation *Fermentation*

The juice is fermented into a base wine of about 9% alcohol. **No sulphur** is added — it would carry through to the spirit — and the wine is distilled soon after, often still on its lees.

Why it matters: anything in the wine ends up concentrated in the still, so purity here is everything.

3. First Distillation *Première chauffe*

In the copper **alambic charentais**, the wine is heated in a first pass — the **première chauffe** — giving a cloudy low-strength spirit called the **brouillis** (about 28–32%).

Why it matters: Cognac's signature is that it is distilled **twice** — this is the first of the two passes.

4. Second Distillation *Bonne chauffe*

The brouillis is distilled again — the **bonne chauffe**. Now the distiller makes **the cut**, discarding the harsh heads and tails and keeping only the clean **cœur** (heart), at around 70% alcohol.

Why it matters: the skill of the cut decides the quality of the whole spirit — keep too much and it turns coarse.

5. Oak Ageing *Vieillissement*

The clear spirit is aged in French oak (Limousin, Tronçais), which gives it colour, spice and roundness. Each year a little evaporates — the **angels' share**. Age drives the classifications from **vsop** up to XO.

Why it matters: a colourless, fiery spirit becomes amber, mellow Cognac only through years in wood.

6. Blending & Reduction *Assemblage & réduction*

The cellar master marries many eaux-de-vie of different ages and crus — the **assemblage** — then brings the strength down to about 40% by **reduction**.

Why it matters: almost all Cognac is a blend; consistency and complexity are built at this table.

7. Bottling *Mise en bouteille*

The finished Cognac is bottled — it does not age further once out of the barrel and into glass.

Why it matters: unlike wine, a spirit's age is fixed the day it leaves the cask.

Armagnac

1. Harvest *Vendange*

France's oldest brandy, from Gascony. The wine is made from **ugni blanc** with Baco, Folle Blanche and Colombard — a more aromatic mix than Cognac's.

Why it matters: the grape mix, especially Baco, gives Armagnac its rustic, fuller-flavoured character.

2. Fermentation *Fermentation*

As for Cognac, a low-alcohol base wine is fermented without sulphur, ready for the still.

Why it matters: a clean base wine keeps the spirit true to its fruit.

3. Continuous Distillation *Distillation continue*

Here is the great difference from Cognac: Armagnac is usually distilled **once**, in a continuous **alambic armagnaçais** column still. It comes off at a lower strength (52–60%), keeping more flavour and body.

Why it matters: single, low-strength distillation is why Armagnac tastes richer and more rustic than the doubly-distilled Cognac.

4. Oak Ageing *Vieillissement*

Aged in local black oak, Armagnac evolves with its own **angels' share**. Single-vintage bottlings are a proud tradition — while clear, unaged **blanche armagnac** is bottled young.

Why it matters: Armagnac's love of vintages lets you drink a spirit from the exact year of a birthday or anniversary.

5. Blending or Vintage, & Reduction *Assemblage / millésime*

The spirit is either blended (**assemblage**) to a house style and age class, or kept as a single vintage — then reduced towards bottling strength.

Why it matters: whether blend or vintage, this sets the final character and age statement.

6. Bottling *Mise en bouteille*

Bottled and ready — from crystal-clear Blanche to deep, old Hors d'Âge.

Why it matters: Armagnac offers an unusually wide range, from raw-fruit white to decades-old amber.

Marc & Eau-de-Vie

1. The Raw Material *Marc ou fruit*

Two thrifty spirits share one idea — distil what's left, or what's ripe. **Marc** is made from the **pomace** (skins, pips and stalks) left after pressing grapes. A fruit **eau-de-vie** instead starts from whole ripe fruit — pear (poire), cherry (kirsch), plum (mirabelle, quetsche) or raspberry (framboise).

Why it matters: marc turns a winemaking by-product into something precious; fruit eaux-de-vie capture a whole orchard in a glass.

2. Fermentation *Fermentation*

The pomace (with its residual sugars) or the crushed fruit is fermented into an alcoholic mash — the material the still will concentrate.

Why it matters: only sugar that has fermented into alcohol can be distilled — ripe, sound fruit is essential.

3. Distillation *Distillation*

The mash is distilled — in a pot or column still — and the distiller makes **the cut**, keeping only the clean heart of the run.

Why it matters: fruit spirits especially demand a careful cut to stay pure and aromatic.

4. Ageing OPTIONAL *Vieillissement*

Grape **marc** is often oak-aged (Marc de Bourgogne, de Champagne, de Gewurztraminer), turning amber and mellow. Most **fruit** eaux-de-vie are **not** aged in wood — they rest in glass or steel to stay crystal-clear and keep their fresh fruit.

Why it matters: wood would mask the delicate fruit of a kirsch or poire — so those stay clear on purpose.

5. Bottling *Mise en bouteille*

Bottled at around 40–45% — the clear fruit eaux-de-vie served ice-cold, the aged marcs sipped slowly like a brandy.

Why it matters: serving temperature and glass bring out the best in each style.

The great French brandies

Cognac — twice-distilled finesse

Cognac is **twice-distilled** in a copper **alambic charentais**. Thin **ugni blanc** wine becomes the cloudy **brouillis**, then the **bonne chauffe** yields the pure **cœur**. Years in Limousin oak — losing an **angels' share** each year — and a final **assemblage** and **reduction** make the smooth amber spirit, graded VS to XO.

Armagnac — France's oldest brandy

Armagnac is usually distilled **once**, in a continuous **alambic armagnaçais**. Lower-strength distillation keeps more flavour, so Armagnac is richer and more rustic than Cognac. Aged in Gascon black oak, it is proudly sold as single vintages — and as clear, unaged **blanche armagnac**.

Marc & Eau-de-Vie — from pomace and fruit

Marc distils the pomace left after pressing (Italy's grappa is the same idea), while a fruit **eau-de-vie** distils fermented fruit — pear, cherry (kirsch), plum. Grape marcs are often oak-aged; fruit spirits usually stay crystal-clear to keep their orchard freshness.

Glossary

Age classifications
Grape brandies are graded by the youngest spirit in the blend: **VS** (≥2 yrs), **VSOP** (≥4 yrs), **Napoléon**, **XO** (≥10 yrs), **Hors d'Âge**.

Alambic armagnaçais — Armagnac still
A small continuous **column still**: the wine trickles down through heated plates in a single pass, giving a lower-strength, more aromatic and rustic spirit than Cognac.

Alambic charentais — Charentais pot still
The copper pot still of Cognac, worked in batches. Its shape and the **double distillation** it performs give Cognac its finesse.

Angels' share — *part des anges*
The wine and spirit that evaporate through the oak each year during ageing — a real, measurable loss (and the name of the dark cellar fungus that feeds on the vapours).

Assemblage — blending
Marrying eaux-de-vie of different ages, crus and casks to build a house style — the art of the cellar master.

Blanche d'Armagnac
Unaged, water-clear Armagnac, rested only in glass or steel — the pure fruit of the spirit before any oak.

Bonne chauffe — the good heating
Cognac's crucial second distillation, where the distiller makes the cut and keeps only the heart.

Brouillis
The cloudy ‘first spirit’ (about 28–32% alc.) off Cognac's first distillation; it is distilled a second time to make the final spirit.

Cœur — the heart
The pure central fraction of the distillation — around 70% alcohol — that becomes the brandy. Heads and tails are discarded or re-distilled.

Eau-de-vie
Literally ‘water of life’ — a clear spirit distilled from fermented fruit or wine. Cognac, Armagnac, marc and fruit brandies are all eaux-de-vie.

Grande Champagne
The most prized of Cognac's six crus (chalky soils), giving the finest, longest-ageing spirits. Petite Champagne, Borderies and the Bois crus follow.

Marc — pomace brandy
A spirit distilled from the *marc*: the skins, pips and stalks left after pressing. Marc de Bourgogne and Marc de Champagne are famous; Italy's grappa is the same idea.

Première chauffe — first heating
Cognac's first distillation, which turns the base wine into the low-strength brouillis.

Reduction — *réduction*
Gradually lowering a cask-strength spirit to bottling strength (about 40%) by adding distilled water or weak ‘petites eaux’.

The cut — *la coupe*
Separating the run into heads (*têtes*), heart (*cœur*) and tails (*queues*). Only the clean heart is kept for ageing.

Ugni Blanc
The tart, high-acid, low-alcohol white grape (Trebbiano) behind most Cognac and Armagnac — a poor table wine but an ideal base for distillation.

Interactive guide to French brandy & eau-de-vie · A Quick Glance at French Wine · Chris Paul.
Works fully offline — a single self-contained file.